

Atlantic Ocean

Dividing North and South America from Europe and Africa, the Atlantic is the second largest ocean. It is getting wider all the time, at a rate of 1 in (2.5 cm) per year. This is because the Atlantic has a long spreading rift at its heart and few of the subduction zones that destroy the ocean floor.

FACT FILE

Area:	41,100,000 sq miles (106,400,000 sq km)
Average depth:	10,830 ft (3,300 m)
Deepest point:	28,230 ft (8,605 m)

Antilles arc



▲ ACTIVE VOLCANO

Steam and gas erupt from Soufrière Hills volcano on Montserrat, Leeward Islands.

The Windward and Leeward islands, on the fringes of the Caribbean, form an island arc above one of just two subduction zones in the Atlantic. Here, part of the ocean floor is diving beneath the Caribbean, creating the deep Puerto Rico Trench and triggering the eruption of a chain of volcanoes.

Iceland hotspot



▲ BASALT COLUMNS

Cooling volcanic basalt has shrunk and split into these spectacular rock columns.

In the far north, part of the Atlantic Ocean floor has been raised above sea level by a plume of heat beneath the Mid-Atlantic Ridge. It has formed the volcanic landscape of Iceland, with its lava fields of black basalt, hot geysers, ice caps, and glaciers.

Mid-Atlantic Ridge

The Atlantic started forming 180 million years ago, as a rift in Earth's crust that divided a vast continent. As the rift opened up, new rock formed the floor of a widening ocean and the rift became the Mid-Atlantic Ridge. New rock is still erupting from cracks in the ridge, like the one seen below.



► DIVIDING THE WORLD

The Atlantic Ocean is about 3,000 miles (5,000 km) wide, and more than 9,000 miles (15,000 km) long. It forms a vast S-shaped gulf, which separates North and South America from Europe and Africa.

